

Giant anteater

Myrmecophaga tridactyla

The giant anteater has a large, tube-shaped skull but a small brain. It has poor eyesight, yet its sense of smell is 40 times greater than that of a human. The tiny mouth at the end of its snout contains no teeth, but its 2-ft- (60-cm-) long tongue is covered in microscopic spines and sticky saliva, which can lap up as many as 35,000 termites per day. The anteater shuffles when walking, yet runs quickly and swims well.

Ripping claws

Ants, termites, and their eggs make up most of the giant anteater's diet. It uses its powerful foreclaws to rip into anthills and termite mounds, and also against predators such as jaguars, pumas, or humans. A giant anteater is not aggressive but can defend itself well as it stands on its hindlegs—balancing its body on its massive tail—and lashes out with its clawed forelimbs. Solitary except when seeking mates, giant anteaters adapt their behavior according to their proximity to humans.

Those living near populated areas are generally nocturnal (the species is threatened by hunting), whereas animals in remote regions feed during the day. They sleep in the shelter of a bush or hollow, with their extremely bushy tail draped over their head and body for warmth.

Once they have mated, female giant anteaters give birth to one offspring after a gestation of about six months. The baby clings to its mother's back for much of its first year, and will stay with her until it is about two years old.

Giant anteaters **flick their tongues** in and out about **150 times per minute**

↔ 3–7 ft (1–2 m)

⚖ 49–86 lb (18–40 kg)

⊗ Vulnerable

🐜 Ants, termites

🏠 

S. Central America to S. South America

black stripe with a white or cream border



long, tubelike snout